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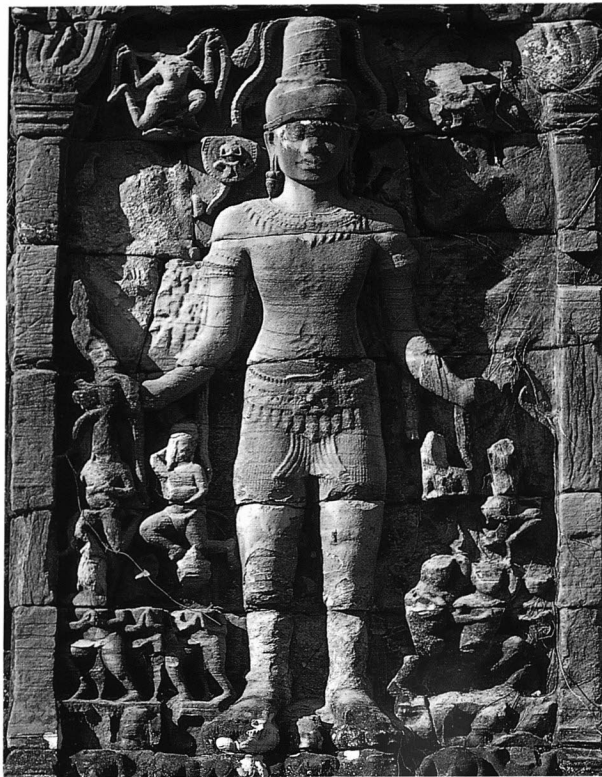
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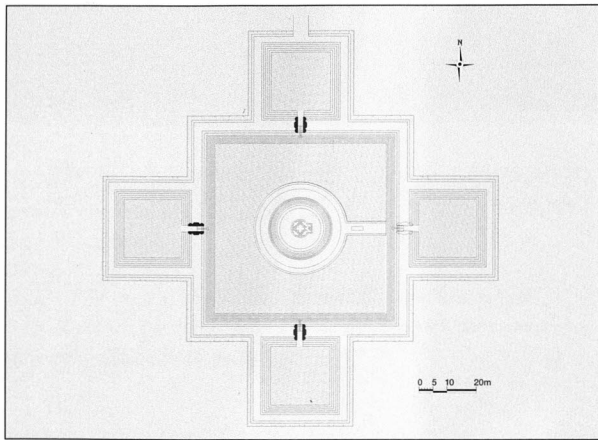
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To provide an indispensable final touch to this religious complex, Jayavarman ordered the construction of a substantial *baray* to the east of the town. It is the Jayatataka, three and a half kilometres long and 900 metres wide, and is nowadays in a dried-out state. In its centre, on a 300 metre square 'island', the striking group today known as Neak Pean was built. The name translates as 'entwined serpents', after the twin snakes wrapped around the base of the main sanctuary.

The main feature of the 'island' is thirteen areas of water, five of which are visible as carved cruciform ponds which have been restored. The central, 70 metre square pond is flanked at the four cardinal points by smaller square ponds which are at least theoretically able to receive the waters of the central pond through gargoyles sheltered by sandstone chapels, and carved with a human head to the east, a lion to the south, a horse to the west and an elephant to the north. In the middle of the central pond is the only sanctuary-tower of the group, rising from a circular base. It is in sandstone, and of relatively modest proportions. Eight further ponds, which lack a masonry facing, completed the rest of the island: four of them are complex in shape, and quite difficult to retrace. A wall surrounded the whole group, and many Buddhist artefacts have been found there. In the central pond itself, to the west, a statue of reclining Vishnu has been discovered, and to the north, some Shivaite *linga*. To the south there was an image damaged beyond recognition, while to the east there is the famous sculpture of the horse Balaha.



Plan of Neak Pean showing the five visible ponds.

Above: A deep relief of Lokeshvara on the southern blind door of the sanctuary of Neak Pean.

Right: Detail of pediment with a flying apsaras.

Opposite: The central sanctuary and pond of Neak Pean.







The fountain head of the east chapel, Neak Pean.

Right: The horse Balaha, a manifestation of Lokeshvara rescuing shipwrecked sailors.

Opposite: The inner enclosure of Ta Som.

It has been claimed that the Neak Pean group is a representation of the Buddhist Anavatapta, a miraculous lake in the Himalayas which heals all illnesses and from which spring four rivers through the mouths of a lion, an elephant, a horse and an ox. This almost matches our site, except that the ox is replaced by a man. But it does not correspond to the words of the Preah Khan stele: the original name was Rajyasri – ‘the fortune of the kingdom’ – and the site was clearly Hinduist. The supposition must therefore be that it was given its Buddhist character during the modifications which must have occurred in the first half of the thirteenth century. These included the walling-in of the south, west and north gates of the main shrine with stones carved with images of Lokeshvara, and probably the group of the horse Balaha. There remains the indubitable fact that the definitive aspect of this unique site in the Khmer country was intended to evoke a specific place. The key to the enigma, unless it is purely Khmer, might well be discovered more or less accidentally in Indian literature.

To the east of the Jayatataka was the temple of Ta Som, famous for the tower carved with faces of its western entrance pavilion, until recently wreathed in the branches and roots of a banyan tree. It was perhaps the temple mentioned as Gaurasrigajaratna – ‘the jewel of the propitious white elephant’, which housed a total of 22 divinities. The stele also records the presence in the Preah Khan group of a Yogindravihara (‘monastery of the king of the *yogin*’), in which, it relates, were ensconced 16 deities, the same number as inhabited each of the two small ponds nearby. It has not yet been identified.



